about 3,700 words

The Hills Above Allentown

by

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There are hills above Allentown, and the one sitting closest to the city is South Mountain. Anyone driving up there after dark comes to a pull-off on the city side, which is a wide gravel lot with room for maybe six cars and a steel guardrail along the edge. Past that rail the mountain drops off fast through red sumac and crooked little oaks, and down at the bottom the whole town is spread out like someone spilled a jar of lights across a dark table. Kids have been climbing up that hill for as long as there's been a road. I'm going to tell what happened to four of them on a Friday in October, when something came up the slope while they were standing at that rail.

Dani Peña's mother zipped the Bible into the front pocket of Dani's backpack every morning at the kitchen table, right after she zipped Dani's coat up to her chin and pulled her braid out from under the collar. It was a small Spanish Bible the size of a paperback, and it had a blue vinyl cover with a zipper around three sides like a pencil case. Her mother had bought it in Santiago the week before they flew up to Pennsylvania. On the first page she had written Daniela

Peña Almonte in ballpoint, pressing down hard enough that the name showed through backward on the other side of the paper. Dani was twelve, and for the two years she had lived in Allentown she had been in the English learner class down the hall at South Mountain Middle School. In all that time she had never once opened that front pocket during a school day, so the only thing she noticed about the book was that her backpack hung a little heavier on the left.

That Friday the last bell rang at the regular time, and the four of them met on the front steps out on Emaus Avenue. A custodian was working the walk with a push broom, sweeping a busted bag of Takis into a dustpan while the wind kept picking up the little red pieces and blowing them back down the steps away from him.

Isaiah Whitfield had the plan, the way he usually did. He was thirteen and in the eighth grade, and he already had his phone screwed onto a small tripod with bendy legs from his birthday, holding it out in front of him like a flashlight.

"Everybody keeps posting the lights," he said. "White lights over South Mountain, real low, no sound. Two hundred comments under every video, and it's aliens, it's ghosts, it's the end of the world." He turned the phone so they could see the screen. "It's drones. Or it's planes coming into the airport and the angle is weird. I'm going to get it clear, from close, and put it up, and that's the end of it."

"From close how?" Yadiel asked.

"From the pull-off. Right over top of where they come up."

Yadiel Rosario was thirteen too, and he was the tallest of them by a head. That day he was wearing his older brother's William Allen hoodie with the canary on the front, and the sleeves hung down past his fingers. His family was Puerto Rican, and his abuela lived with them in the back bedroom of a row house off Fourth Street. Every morning she prayed out loud in the

kitchen with the radio turned up, so the whole house got prayed for whether people were awake or not.

"My abuela says don't go up the mountain after dark," he said.

"So we come down before dark."

"Sunset is at six-thirty," Dani said. She had looked it up on her phone at lunch, because she had known since Wednesday that they were going up there whether she said yes or no. "We have three hours."

The fourth kid was Bryce Kressley, who was eleven and in the sixth grade, and small for his age. He lived two doors down from Isaiah with his grandmother, who said "ach" whenever she dropped a pot lid and always kept a jar of pickled eggs in the refrigerator door. Bryce was carrying her binoculars around his neck in a cracked leather case. Every fall she used them to count hawks up at Hawk Mountain, and she had let him bring them along only after making him promise twice at the front door that he would have them back home before dark.

They walked a couple of blocks up Emaus and turned onto a side street that kept climbing past the last houses, where the sidewalk ended and the patchy pavement gave out into a gravel shoulder under the trees. Everyone who went to South Mountain knew where the path was. It started behind a yellow sign saying the road wasn't maintained in winter, and it went up through the woods in a long zigzag that had been worn down to dirt and roots by about a hundred years of kids.

It was warm for an October afternoon, warm enough that all four of them were sweating inside of ten minutes. The oaks were just starting to turn brown, while the poplars had already dropped their leaves, so the path was covered in dry leaves that crunched under their feet and slid a little before catching. Dani was wearing her flat black school shoes with no grip on the soles,

and twice she slipped down onto one knee. The second time it happened, Yadiel reached his hand back without turning around, and she took it so he could pull her up the steep part. Neither one of them said anything about it afterward. Halfway up the hill, a single white roller skate with pink laces was lying on its back in the leaves beside the trail, and all four of its wheels were gone. Bryce poked it with his sneaker as he walked past, and that was all anyone did with it.

Isaiah talked most of the way up the trail, going on about frame rates and the zoom on his phone, and how people would believe almost anything they saw in a video if it was blurry enough. Bryce asked him what he thought the lights were if they turned out not to be drones, and Isaiah said they were going to be drones.

"But if it isn't," Bryce said.

"Then it's planes."

"But if it isn't planes."

Isaiah stopped on the path and put both hands on his knees to catch his breath. "My mom says people see what they need to see," he said. "She says that's what church is. People needed a story, so they got one. She quit going when I was eight."

Yadiel said, "My abuela says your mom is going to come back."

"Your abuela says that about everybody."

"She's been right about a lot of everybody," Yadiel said, and he kept walking up the path ahead of them, which was the end of that conversation.

They came out of the trees at the top a little after five, stepping onto the road shoulder right above the pull-off with their faces red and all four of them breathing hard. No one else was up there, though a car had turned around in the lot not long before and left fresh tire tracks

curved across the gravel. The only sounds were the wind moving through the sumac below the rail and the traffic way down on the city streets.

Below the guardrail, the sumac had turned as deep red as a stop sign, the way it always does in October, running down the slope in a thick tangle into the scrub oak and the backyards of the first houses. Off to their left, the flat orange sun was dropping out toward Trexlertown and throwing long shadows from every church steeple and smokestack across the roofs. Right in the middle of downtown, the tall pale PPL Building stood above the rest of the skyline with its top lights already on, the same as every night anyone in town could remember. Hamilton Street ran east from there as its streetlights came on one by one. Past that was the dark cut of the Lehigh River, and far off to the right, beyond the fold of the hills, the old steel stacks in Bethlehem were lit up in colored lights against the sky. A slow freight train was rolling along the river, and at every crossing the engineer gave two long pulls on the horn, with the sound taking a couple of seconds to reach them up on the mountain.

Isaiah wrapped the bendy tripod legs around the top of a guardrail post until the phone sat tight, and then he aimed the camera over the sumac and hit record. The steel rail felt cold through the sleeve of Dani's coat when she leaned against it. Years back, someone had painted J.R. + M.T. in silver on the post beside her, and most of the M had flaked away.

They stood there waiting while the sun dropped behind the far ridge, and the city shifted from orange to blue as the streetlights took over. Bryce kept the binoculars up to his eyes and called out whatever he spotted, which was a man walking a dog in a park, a city bus, and a pigeon sitting on top of a church. Yadiel opened a bag of chips he had been saving since lunch and started eating them by himself, until Dani looked over at him and he held the bag out to share.

At twenty minutes to seven, the first light came up out of the sumac.

It was close, which was the first thing wrong about it. Everyone in the video comments had talked about lights high up in the sky over the mountain, but this one was down below them. It rose out of the red bushes about a hundred feet down the slope and stopped even with the tops of the scrub oak, so the four kids were looking down at it with the city spread out behind it. The light was white and about the size of a basketball, and it didn't blink. Then a second one came up beside it, followed by a third, and all three hung there in a row in the dusk without making a sound.

"Drones," Isaiah said.

"There's no buzz," Bryce said, looking through the binoculars. "There's no propellers. I can see the bushes right through the bottom of them. Isaiah, there's no anything holding them up."

Isaiah's phone was still recording on the post, lighting his face up white from the screen, and he didn't reach for it.

All four of their phones lit up at the same time. Dani's buzzed in her coat pocket, Yadiel's buzzed in the front of his hoodie, and Bryce's went off in his back pocket loud enough to make him jump. Then the speaker on Isaiah's phone clicked on, and a voice came out of it that sounded like the map lady on a phone, the one that tells a driver to turn left in four hundred feet, calm and friendly and a little slow.

"Isaiah," the voice said. "You came to see us. Go ahead and ask."

Yadiel reached out and grabbed a fistful of the back of Isaiah's hoodie. Isaiah didn't try to shake him off. He stood at the rail with his mouth slightly open, then closed it and set his jaw the way he did in science class whenever Mr. Ortiz said something he didn't buy.

"How many cars on that train?" Isaiah said.

"Ninety-one," said the map lady.

"Bryce," Isaiah said. "Count it."

Bryce swung the binoculars over toward the river. His hands were shaking so hard that he had to brace both elbows on the cold steel rail, and he counted the cars out loud under his breath. It took a couple of minutes because the train was long and the back half of it was passing behind buildings. Nobody moved while he counted, and when he reached the end he lowered the binoculars and didn't say the number right away.

"Ninety-one," he said.

"What's my grandmother's middle name?" Isaiah asked.

"Loretta," said the voice, and Isaiah's hand closed tight on the top of the guardrail.

"We were here before your city," the map lady said. "We were here before the river had its name. We made the first of you, ages ago, and then we went away, and now we have come back for the ones who can see. You can see, Isaiah. The others are not ready. Step over the rail and come down, and we will show you where you came from. You can bring your camera."

The three lights drifted a little closer up the slope. Underneath them the sumac started moving, with all the red leaves flipping over to show their pale undersides even though there wasn't any wind on the kids' faces.

Isaiah put his palm flat on top of the rail, and then he lifted his left knee up onto the steel.

"Isaiah," Yadiel said. "No, bro. No."

"They answered," Isaiah said. "They answered everything. You heard them."

Isaiah swung his leg over to the far side. Past the guardrail there was only about two feet of loose gravel before the sumac dropped straight down the slope with nowhere to set a foot. His

sneaker hit the gravel and slid out from under him, and he had to grab the rail to catch himself. Yadiel still had a fistful of his hoodie. Bryce let the binoculars drop against his chest, grabbed the back of Isaiah's belt with both hands, and sat down hard in the gravel with his heels dug in, the way someone holds a big dog on a leash.

Dani unzipped the front pocket of her backpack.

She had never once opened it at school, and now her fingers were stiff from the cold as she pulled the Bible out and held it closed against her coat with both hands. Back in Santiago, sitting on the edge of the bed while the fan ran, her mother had told her one thing that she had never needed to use until tonight. If a voice ever came to her and didn't seem right, her mother had said, she should ask it about Jesus, and ask if He came in the flesh. Anything from God would tell her yes, and the others wouldn't say it.

"Una pregunta," Dani said. Her voice came out small at first, so she spoke up louder. "¿Jesucristo vino en carne? Sí o no." Then she said it again in English for the boys, slow and careful, the way she read out loud in Mrs. Bauer's class. "I have one question. Jesus Christ came in the body. Yes or no?"

Isaiah's phone stayed silent on top of the post, with the little red recording dot still blinking in the corner of the screen.

The three lights hung over the sumac, and the leaves underneath them stopped moving. Down by the river, the train blew its horn for another crossing, and the sound climbed the mountain and faded past them.

"Answer her," Isaiah said.

He was still straddling the wrong side of the rail, with one leg over the edge and Bryce's full weight pulling back on his belt.

"You did the train," he said. "You did my grandma. Answer her. It's a yes or a no."

"Isaiah," said the map lady, in that same friendly voice. "Come down."

"Answer her question first."

"Come down, Isaiah. The others are not ready."

Isaiah stood there with the phone screen lighting up his face, and it was clear he was working through it the same way he worked through a test at school. They had passed both of the checks he gave them. They knew the train count and they knew his grandmother's name, but there was one question they wouldn't touch, and it was Dani's. He looked down at the lights, then over at the small blue Bible in Dani's hands, and back to the lights again. Then he swung his leg back over the guardrail. His knee bumped the tripod and spun it halfway around on the post, knocking Bryce backward into the gravel, and Isaiah planted his feet on the safe side of the rail with both hands holding tight to the steel.

The lights came up the hill.

They came fast and all together, tearing up through the sumac and the scrub oak while the bushes thrashed underneath them like a herd of deer bolting up the slope. All four of their phones started buzzing at once and wouldn't quit. From Isaiah's speaker the map lady's voice started repeating turn left, turn left, turn left, getting faster and faster until the words ran together into one sound. Up close the lights looked much bigger and had lost their round shape, though none of the four kids would ever agree later on what shape they had turned into.

Yadiel let go of Isaiah's hoodie and stepped up to the guardrail in front of the other three. He spoke the way his abuela had spoken in the kitchen the time the pan grease caught fire, loud and flat and sure while she reached for the lid with her other hand.

"En el nombre de Jesús," he said. "In the name of Jesus. Get off this mountain."

The lights stopped about twenty feet down the slope, halting so hard it looked like they had slammed into an invisible fence, and they hung there shaking. Then all three dropped straight down into the sumac like stones into a pond and shot out the bottom, skimming low over the rooftops, across Hamilton Street, and out over the river toward the dark around the airport until the kids couldn't tell them from the city lights anymore.

Every phone shut off at once. The regular wind came back up through the sumac, and they could hear the traffic down on the streets again.

That was when Bryce realized his grandmother's binoculars were gone. The thin strap on the binoculars had snapped when he sat down hard in the gravel, leaving only the empty leather case hanging around his neck on its own strap. He felt around in the dark gravel where he had been sitting, and when he didn't find them he got up on his knees and looked over the rail, where the steep slope dropped away into the dark red bushes.

"Those are my grandma's," he said. "Those are for the hawks."

"Nobody goes over that rail," Yadiel said. "Not tonight. Not for anything."

Bryce stayed on his knees looking down into the dark bushes, and then he stood up, brushed the gravel off the seat of his jeans, and didn't go over.

They walked down the mountain path in the dark. Halfway down the trail, Isaiah's phone came back on by itself with four percent battery left, so he turned on the flashlight and walked in front with his arm held out ahead of them, and nobody said a word the rest of the way. Dani carried the blue Bible in her hand the whole walk down instead of putting it back in her backpack. When they came out onto the first street with houses at the bottom, a man was standing on a stepladder on his front porch, either stringing Christmas lights along the gutter in

the middle of October or taking down last year's, and they never did figure out which one he was doing.

That night Isaiah plugged his phone in to charge on his bedroom floor and sat with his back against the bed while the radiator under the window ticked and knocked, warming up for the first time that fall. The two hundred comments he had been counting on never happened, because every video he had shot that evening was gone from his phone except for one eleven-second clip. When his knee bumped the tripod, it had spun the phone halfway around on the post, so for those eleven seconds the camera was pointing back at the four of them instead of out over the city. The clip shows Isaiah's leg coming back over the guardrail, Bryce falling backward into the gravel, Yadiel letting go of the hoodie to step up to the rail, and Dani in her coat holding the small blue Bible against her chest with both hands. Behind Dani, standing on the pull-off gravel where nobody had been a second earlier, there's a tall shape that stands a good deal higher than any grown man. Its back is turned to the camera, and one of its hands is resting on the guardrail right beside Dani as it faces down the hill the same way she is. None of the four kids saw anyone standing there at the time. Isaiah watched those eleven seconds about forty times that night, but he didn't post the video, and he still hasn't posted it. If anyone asks him about that night, he says the tall one never turns around, and he would really like to know who it is.

On Monday morning, while the kitchen radio was giving the traffic report on Route 22, Dani's mother picked up the blue Bible from the table to zip it into the front pocket of the backpack like she always did. Before she could do it, Dani took the Bible from her mother's hands and slid it into the right pocket of her own coat, where she could reach it fast. Her mother let her keep it there, and she stood in the doorway watching Dani walk down the steps toward Emaus Avenue with her hand inside that pocket and her thumb resting on the zipper pull.

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